GRADE 4 · ART & ART HISTORY · ONE LESSON

Castles, Cathedrals & Colorful Glass

Art and architecture of the Middle Ages

Time About 45–60 minutes	**You will need** Colored pencils or markers, a gold or yellow crayon, a ruler
Big idea People in the Middle Ages used art and buildings to stay safe, to worship, and to tell stories.	**By the end, I can…** • tell how castles kept people safe • compare Romanesque and Gothic churches • name three kinds of medieval art

Warm-up: Think of the biggest building you have ever been inside. How do you think people built giant buildings 800 years ago, with no cranes, trucks, or electricity? Talk about it for one minute.

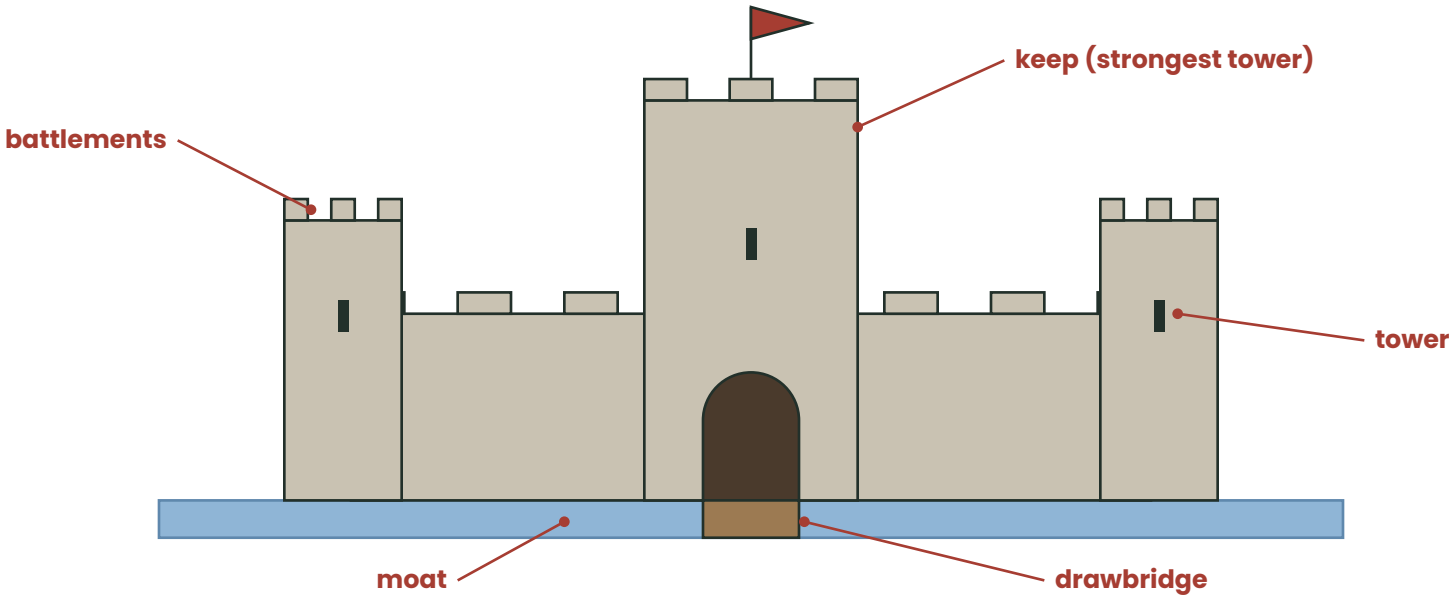
What were the Middle Ages?

The **Middle Ages** (also called the **medieval** period) lasted about 1,000 years, from around the year 500 to around 1500. They are called the "middle" ages because they came *between* the time of ancient Rome and the modern world.

In Europe, most people were farmers. Kings and lords ruled the land, and knights fought for them. The Christian Church was at the center of almost everyone's life. Very few people could read, so **pictures were a way to tell stories**, and art was everywhere: on walls, in windows, and in books.

Castles: built to stay safe

Lords and kings built **castles** to protect their families, soldiers, and land. At first castles were made of wood. Later they were made of stone, which was much harder to burn or knock down.



- A **moat** was a deep ditch, often filled with water, that kept attackers away from the walls.
- The **drawbridge** could be pulled up to close the gate.
- **Battlements** are the up-and-down shapes on top of the walls. Soldiers could hide behind the high parts and shoot arrows through the gaps.
- The **keep** was the tallest, strongest tower, the last safe place if enemies got inside.

Cathedrals: buildings that reach for the sky

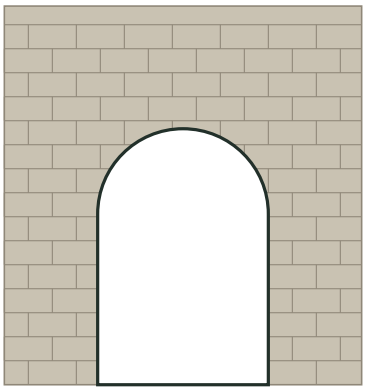
A **cathedral** is a large, important church. Building one could take 100 years or more, so the workers who started it often never saw it finished. Medieval churches were built in two main styles.

Romanesque style (about 1000–1150)

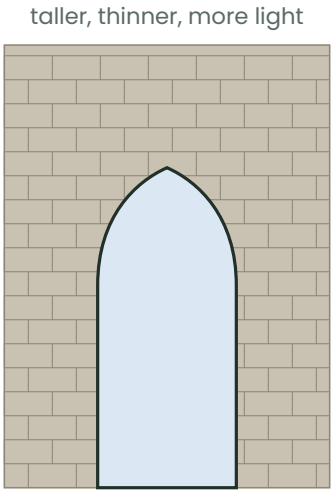
Romanesque churches have **round arches**, very thick walls, and small windows. They look strong and heavy, almost like a fortress, and they are often dark inside. The walls had to be thick to hold up the heavy stone roof.

Gothic style (starting about 1140)

Builders in France found new tricks. **Pointed arches** push the weight of the roof down more steeply, so the buildings could be much taller. Stone arms on the outside called **flying buttresses** helped hold up the walls. Because the walls no longer had to carry all the weight, builders could fill them with huge, colorful windows. Famous Gothic cathedrals include **Notre-Dame de Paris** and **Chartres Cathedral** in France.

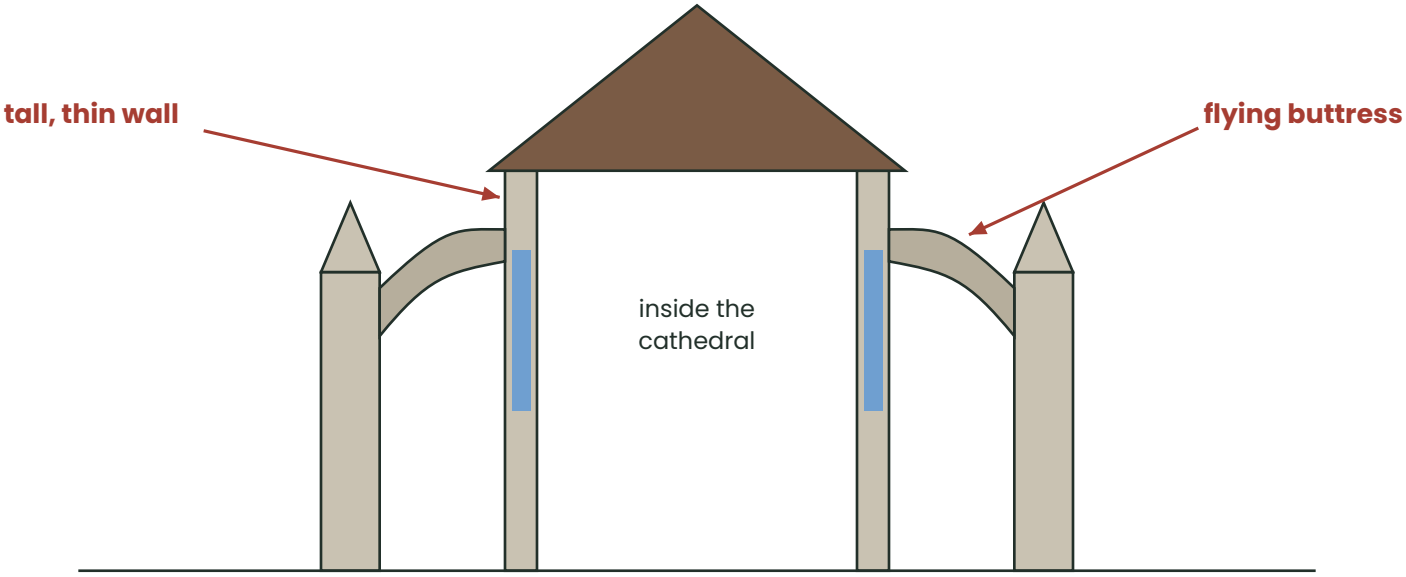


ROMANESQUE: round arch



GOTHIC: pointed arch

Look closely: which arch looks taller and lighter?



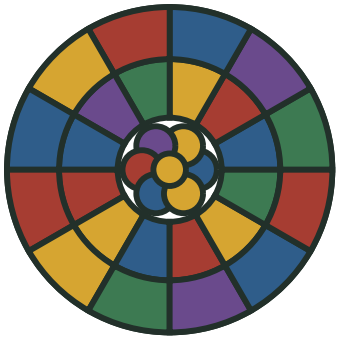
The stone arms push in and hold the high walls up, so the walls can be full of windows.

Fun fact: gargoyles

Many Gothic cathedrals have stone creatures called **gargoyles** on the roof. They have a real job! Rainwater runs through them and spouts out of their mouths, away from the walls.

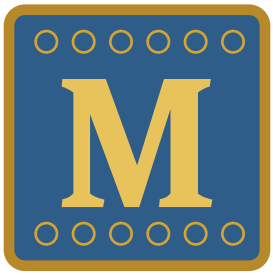
Art that tells stories

Most medieval art had a job to do: to teach a story, to honor God, or to show important events. Here are four kinds of art you would have seen.



Stained glass

Artists cut small pieces of colored glass and held them together with strips of lead, like a puzzle. When sunlight shines through, the whole church glows with color. Windows showed Bible stories so people who could not read could still "read" the pictures. A big round window like this is called a **rose window**.



Illuminated manuscripts

Before printing machines, every book was copied **by hand**, often by monks. They wrote on **parchment**, made from animal skin, and decorated the pages with bright paint and real gold. The gold made the pages seem to glow, or "light up." That is why they are called **illuminated**. The first letter of a page was often huge and fancy, like this M. One famous example is the **Book of Kells**, made in Ireland around the year 800.

Tapestries and embroidery

Big cloth pictures hung on cold stone castle walls. They looked beautiful and helped keep rooms warm. The **Bayeux Tapestry** is about 230 feet long, as long as two and a half basketball courts! It tells the story of a famous battle in the year 1066, a bit like a giant comic strip sewn with wool thread.

Mosaics

A **mosaic** is a picture made from tiny pieces of colored stone or glass. In the Byzantine Empire, the eastern part of the old Roman world, churches such as the **Hagia Sophia** in Constantinople (today Istanbul, Turkey) were covered with shining gold mosaics.

Around the world at the same time

The Middle Ages were not only happening in Europe. Muslim artists and builders created amazing places too, like the **Alhambra** palace in Spain. Instead of pictures of people, they often used **geometric patterns**, shapes that repeat again and again, and beautiful handwriting called **calligraphy**.

Words to know

medieval	having to do with the Middle Ages, about 500–1500
cathedral	a large, important church
Romanesque	a building style with round arches, thick walls, and small windows
Gothic	a building style with pointed arches, tall walls, and big windows
flying buttress	a stone arm on the outside of a building that helps hold up its walls
stained glass	colored glass pieces joined together to make a picture
illuminated manuscript	a hand-written book decorated with bright colors and gold
tapestry	a large picture made with thread on cloth
mosaic	a picture made of tiny pieces of stone or glass

Check what you learned

1. Name two parts of a castle and tell how each one kept people safe.

2. How is a Romanesque church different from a Gothic church? Give two differences.

3. What job did a flying buttress do?

4. Why were stained-glass windows so important for people who could not read?

5. Why do you think monks used real gold in illuminated manuscripts?

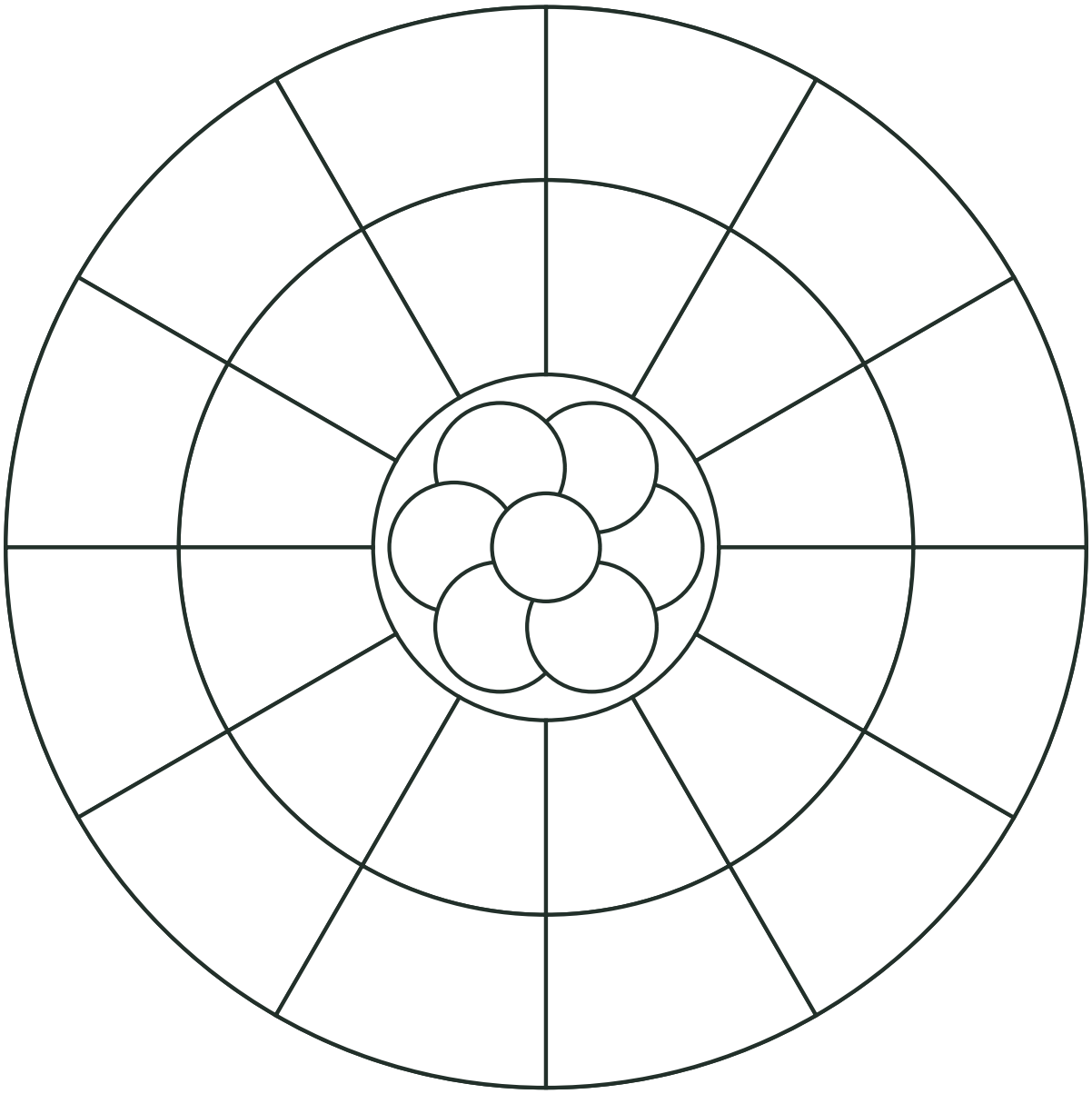
Be an artist: choose one

A. Illuminate your initial	B. Design a rose window
Draw the first letter of your name in the square. Make it big and fancy. Fill the space around it with vines, animals, or patterns. Use yellow or gold to make it "glow."	Color the rose window on the next page. Repeat your colors in a pattern all the way around the circle, the way medieval glassmakers did. Outline every piece with a dark line for the lead.

Your illuminated initial

Rose window coloring page

Gothic cathedrals like Notre-Dame de Paris have giant rose windows. Color yours with a repeating pattern.



FOR THE TEACHER

Answer guide and teaching notes

1. Any two: moat (kept attackers away from the walls), drawbridge (could be raised to close the gate), battlements (soldiers hid behind them and shot through the gaps), keep (strongest tower, last place of safety), thick stone walls (hard to burn or break).

2. Romanesque: round arches, thick heavy walls, small windows, darker inside. Gothic: pointed arches, taller and thinner walls, flying buttresses, large stained-glass windows, brighter inside.

3. It pushed against the high walls from outside to hold them up, so the walls could be thinner and hold big windows.

4. The pictures told Bible stories and other lessons, so people could learn them by looking.

5. Accept reasoned answers: to make the book glow, to show the words were precious or holy, to honor God, to show wealth.

Teaching notes

- **Pacing:** warm-up 5 min · read and discuss pages 1–4, about 20–25 min · check questions 10 min · art activity 15–20 min.
- **Hands-on demo:** Hold a sheet of paper upright: it falls. Lean a book against each side and it stands. That is what a buttress does.
- **Look it up together:** search for photos of Chartres Cathedral's windows, the Book of Kells, the Bayeux Tapestry, and the Alhambra, and compare them with the drawings in this lesson.
- **Extension:** Ask students which they would rather build, a castle or a cathedral, and why. Have them write 3–4 sentences.